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Ralph LaLama

Tenor saxophonist Ralph LaLama was born in West Aliquippa, Pennsylvania on January 30, 1951. His big band experience includes stints with Buddy Rich, Woody Herman and the Vanguard Jazz Orchestra. Ralph has co-led a quartet with fellow saxophonist Joe Lovano and records as a leader on the Criss-Cross label.

Ralph was interviewed in Utica, New York on May 23, 2010 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am off-camera for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and I am very pleased to be speaking with saxophonist Ralph LaLama today. Welcome back to Utica, New York.

RL: Thank you, Monk. Yeah, it's nice to be here. We had a good gig yesterday, two gigs, yes. People are nice around here. You know I used to play here. Tiny's and do some concerts, and did a bunch of stuff for J.R. [Monterose], did a couple of benefits for Phyllis [Monterose], I remember with Nick [Brignola] and Joe Mags [Magnarelli] and you know Rick [Montalbano]. I remember Rick [Montalbano] Junior —

MR: Yeah me too.

RL: Yeah but I mean when he was tiny, man, like he would sit in with us. And yesterday he played the gigs with us.

MR: Yeah isn't that something?

RL: Yeah it is funny.

MR: It sort of makes you feel like am I that old?

RL: Right.

MR: I was told Utica, I'm not a native of here but I'm from Rochester, but I was told that Utica used to be like a midway point, sort of guys would travel the Thruway and —

RL: That's right. Come between Rochester — you know I have, I don't know if this is part of the question but I'm going to say it here — I have an affinity here for Upstate New York because I'm from Pittsburgh and I've been living in New York for about 35 years. But I grew up in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. And I went to school at Youngstown State University. And why that's relevant is there was a guy that was going to school at the time, he just got off of Woody Herman's band, his name was Tony Leonardi. And he was from Syracuse, okay. So he grew up with Sal [Amico], he played with Chuck [Mangione] and you know he played with Joe Romano and Nick and probably J.R. too. But Tony was kind of my mentor, you know. Even though he was about eleven years older than me. And at Youngstown State he started which was at that time a one hour elective jazz band.

It wasn't part of the curriculum really except for it was an elective. So my point is that Tony turned me on to all kinds of great, you know he heard I played — I auditioned for the band. I didn't know the band. I just auditioned for the band, I made it, and we started becoming with friends, and he turned me on to all these hip — then I remember he invited Sal Nistico to the school, so we could hear him, you know? And he played with us, and then I got to know Sal. Now again when I moved to New York I moved to Queens, Elmhurst Queens. And at that time Sal lived in Rego Park. And Sal was nice enough, you know, because he remembered me and he knew I was trying to play and all that stuff, and so he put me on some of his gigs, you know, like quartet gigs, he made them a quintet for little Ralphie to play. You know what I mean? Right out of school, I was in my early twenties. Because I got out of Woody Herman's band and Sal was there, and Tony Leonardi played — you know I didn't play with him, I mean in Woody's band, but I mean they were alumni. Joe Romano. I met Joe, coming to New York, and then Nick I played with up here. So the only one I didn't know that well was J.R. because he was already gone playing when I started. So I always feel like, not that this is my home, but I always felt like very close to the Upstate guys because of Tony, and then Sal, and then Joe you know, and even Chuck.

MR: And all these Upstate guys are, you know their last name always ends with a vowel.

RL: Yeah that's right.

MR: It's something about Italians.

RL: Well that's it: Lovano, LaLama, you know, Nistico. Even Zito or a's.

MR: Very interesting. A couple of books have come out recently about that. Italian Americans in the jazz world.

RL: That's right. That's true. Most definitely.

MR: I wanted to pose a question to you. If you were able to write your own entry about yourself for a new coming jazz book, like a jazz encyclopedia, and you could actually write it yourself, you might say, " Ralph LaLama sounds reminiscent of" blank and blank. Like two tenor players.

RL: Oh two tenors.

MR: Who would you pick?

RL: I would probably have to say Sonny Rollins and Hank Mobley.

MR: Well you know it's interesting because the guy who wrote the entry for the *Grove Encyclopedia of Jazz* said exactly that.

RL: Oh did he.

MR: Yeah. I'm not sure of his name but I just looked in there and that's exactly what it said, that those were like big influences on you. And I noticed yesterday, I was so pleased when you started out the concert with that Hank Mobley tune.

RL: Oh yeah, "Dis I Dig of You" that's right.

MR: Not many people — well at least in my experience — have heard that played a lot.

RL: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Yeah, because that's my influence. I mean you know I remember when I was growing up, I mean like jazz growing up let's put it that way, it was in the 70s and everybody started playing like Coltrane. And I like Coltrane, I mean he's one of my influences too, and Joe Henderson and those guys. But I was always towards the Sonny thing. And then moving to New York, I was different. Because I was trying to play like Sonny and everybody else was going Trane, you know? I don't know, it probably helped me a little bit and hindered me a little bit. You know, because if they wanted the status quo they wouldn't hire me, if they wanted something a little different they would hire me.

MR: I see.

RL: And I didn't do that for any business reason. I just was turned on by it.

MR: Well what, at the time, can you put into words what was the different approach, if you were more into Sonny than Trane? Less notes?

RL: Less notes, more melody, more rhythm. I mean not that Trane didn't play with rhythm, I don't want to be quoted as saying that. But Sonny had a spontaneity. A melodic and rhythmic spontaneity I think compared to — Trane was more practiced. And even though, I mean it worked, you know don't get me wrong, it's not a put down by any means. It's just what I was attracted to. It's what I went towards. It's what I like. You know you've got to be honest with yourself. And back in Youngstown prior to that, it's what my father used to listen to. He used to listen to Sonny Stitt, Gene Ammons, Stan Getz. I mean I didn't even hear Sonny Rollins and Trane at first, or even Charlie [Parker] until I met Tony. It wasn't in the air in my house. I heart Stitt, singers, my mother was a singer, my father was a drummer. So I had music in the house, it was in the air, that's the way I would put it. I like James Brown. You know, because you're a kid. You know, not that I didn't like jazz, I did. But James Brown, when you're growing up, I mean that's my generation. James Brown, the Temptations, you know.

MR: And you got your rhythmic dose from that.

RL: That's right. Totally. From James, oh definitely. No doubt about it.

MR: You know I think you can learn a lot, even if you're a jazz player, from listening to what those horn players are playing behind him and all those things.

RL: Yeah. And the rhythm section, the feeling. The feeling. James Brown — I still love it. I mean to me that's how good it is. When I put it on now, after all I've been through in a musical sense, I still enjoy it as much. So to me that's true art. That might not be in the books as art, but to me it is. Because I get a kick out of it. It's not just nostalgic either. It's a feeling.

MR: You had your big band experiences under three kind of different leaders. You had Mel Lewis and Buddy Rich and Woody Herman. Who did you enjoy the most?

RL: Well I can't, that's a hard — here I could explain it in a certain way. My first band was Woody Herman and that was like my first professional jazz gig so to speak. I mean I'd played a lot of gigs, but I don't mean professional as far as getting paid, but upper eschelons jazz. And Woody, and I just learned a lot. I learned a lot from Woody because of the fact that I finally realized that a leader has to trust you. I don't mean just showing up on time, but the music and showing up on time, and just being there for the gig. That's when he starts liking you, when he trusts you. And that was a big lesson. I mean it just hit me one day, oh man, that's how you get along.

MR: To trust you to not only play but —

RL: Be there, and you know, just be there. But even the music too. I mean musically he has to trust you. When you go up to play, let's say a solo, you're going to be right. You know? I'm not saying you can't make a mistake, I mean it's just the attitude. And okay, and then I went to Buddy Rich and I really enjoyed that too. Well Buddy was a lunatic but still he was a real musician. I'm not totally agreeable when I hear all these stories. Not that they weren't true, but his attitude really wasn't like — he was a musician, you know what I mean? And he wanted things right. I can tell you a couple of stories. I remember one time the whole trumpet section was gone and they hired all these guys from North Texas State. And they really weren't up to snuff. I mean they couldn't handle — and we all figured oh Buddy, he's going to go crazy. He didn't say a word. He just fired them. He gave them their two weeks notice. You know why? Because he knew they weren't that talented. But he would holler at you if he knew you were talented and you weren't doing the job, you know? So I respected him. You know what I mean? And I remember another time he invited Mel Lewis to the band because he couldn't even get dressed, he had this back problem with his discs. He couldn't get dressed, right? So I remember they had to help him get dressed. He would get dressed on the bus. But I remember Mel was there for a week but didn't play one beat. Because Buddy would, after all that pain — I mean I saw this guy was in pain. You know when somebody is in pain, they're not faking it you know. So he would go up there and play. And then he'd go back, and he was in pain. So he had Mel Lewis there, but Mel didn't play a note. Okay now in London I ended up, we were there for a month, we were at Ronnie Scott's for a week but I got sick, I had the flu, I had to go to the doctor, you know, I mean I had a 103 temperature. I had a terrible flu. And Steve Marcus and Andy Fusco went into Buddy's room and said, "Buddy, man, Ralph is sick, I mean I don't know if he can play." And he goes, "Is he dead?" They said, "No." And then so I'm on the bandstand and I played and I think he called almost every tune I played on too. Okay. But you know what? If you tell that story out of context that

sounds like Buddy's not a very nice human being. But I could dig him because when he was sick he played. Even though he had a sub, he had Mel Lewis on the bus. Mel didn't play one note.

MR: So he wouldn't ask you do to anything that he wouldn't do.

RL: That's right. That's what I got from him. You know what I mean? So to me that's what I mean, I mean he's crazy but I could dig it. I mean technically, on that band you played much more notes. I don't mean complicated but for me as a saxophone player I learned a lot about the saxophone technique because of some of the music he played. It was like hard, another step. Okay? And then with Mel and Thad, when I got to New York, I mean I knew Thad. I met Thad at Youngstown. Tony Leonardi got Thad to come to Youngstown. So I used to sub on the band. My first gig in New York was with Mel and Thad, but it wasn't the big band, it was a quintet. So that flipped me out. That was my first gig.

MR: You said something yesterday, you said you learned more on that gig on the first few weeks than you did in college. What do you learn on that first — I mean what was so memorable?

RL: Well just what the thing sounded like around you. You know, and how they handled, I mean these were masters of playing jazz music. And I'm just out of college. And Tony Leonardi was great, believe me, I mean I learned a lot from him. But now this is experiencing it. That's what I mean. Even with now you say about the band with Thad and Mel or the Mel Lewis band, that was more like real life. I mean he dealt with a lot — you know it's in your home town which is now New York, you go to work and just the music was so ridiculously challenging at the time especially, and you're with Thad Jones and Mel Lewis and everybody else in the band, when I was subbing, it was Pepper Adams, you know Jerry Dodgion, you know what I mean? All these guys. I said what? Bob Brookmeyer. You know I mean I'm a kid. So for a summation, and I don't want to make this sound weird, because it's not like this, but just to compare it I would say Woody was like high school, Buddy was like college, and Mel was like life. You know what I mean? That's the way I would answer your question, even though it took me a half hour to answer your question.

MR: That's okay. I like long answers. I don't know if I can phrase this question correctly, but in improvisation, in jazz improvisation, to you, what constitutes a wrong note?

RL: Well okay that's a good question. It's like beauty is in the eyes of the beholder, okay? I think there are wrong notes. A lot of people don't. I do. I really do. Because you have a background, you have a chord, and then you could use all twelve notes but it's how you organize them. You know what I mean? It's the organization. Sometimes you might put a wrong note in a wrong part of the beat or something, and it sounds wrong. And I just get

this tension up my spine. You know what I mean? But, then technically you can play a wrong note, technically meaning theoretically it could be a wrong note but it sounds right. You know, because of the placement. You know Thad Jones was the master of it. Coltrane too. Sonny Rollins, all those masters, Joe Henderson. As far as theoretically, in other words we have a chord, we have a scale and we have the chord tone. So if you play outside of that, it could be considered wrong. But if you know how to phrase it exactly right and resolve it right that's another thing. It's in the resolution. You can resolve a wrong note and make it right see. And then sometimes I know when I hit a wrong note, you know like I say I feel it up my spine, and I usually hear it from my wife.

MR: Are you joking?

RL: No. My wife is a great singer, Nicole Pasternak, she's a great singer.

MR: Okay.

RL: And she has great ears too. You know what I mean? But I'm just saying I'm joking but I'm not. I'm serious about what I'm saying. But she doesn't actually holler at me, but I know she can tell when I hit it. But when you're trying to improvise, sometimes you get hung up. So if you just play all your licks that are comfortable, all your stuff, then you're not going to mess up. Then I don't think you're really improvising. You know what I mean? I mean like Monk. Monk. Speaking of Monk, [scats] it's obviously — not a wrong note — but it sounds right. It sounds — there's tension. Let's put it this way: there's tension notes, and there's wrong notes. Ah that's very good Ralph.

MR: We'll quote you on that. You'll make our little snippets of good quotes.

RL: Yeah.

MR: But I noticed yesterday in listening to you —

RL: A lot of wrong notes.

MR: Well no, every once in a while you would end a phrase with a note that made me go, like literally, like gee I wish I would have thought of that. But it sounded pretty cool.

RL: Well that's what I mean. That was tension. That wasn't wrong, hopefully. You know what I mean? I mean that's the way I would interpret it. I don't know, I've been doing that a lot more lately. I've been trying to get a little bit more modern. I don't know, I don't like that term, but in other words I'm just experimenting. And hopefully if all these improvisers do, you know, you don't want to be complacent. I don't. That's boring to me. So I started a very concrete — but that's not the — consonant, I was more consonant when I first started playing. Well this was actually a lot of my upstate influence. You know what I mean? And as I got older and you know you start hearing more, and you hear other guys too, I get influenced by other people too. I'll be honest about that. I'm definitely influenced by what things are around me at the moment and at different places and in different cultures. Because I'm lucky, I get to go around the world.

MR: You've spent some time in Italy right?

RL: Oh yeah.

MR: What do you do there?

RL: Well I do some teaching over there and actually with the Vanguard band we go once a year to Assisi, where we play a couple of concerts and we also do clinics, you know? And at one time I did something for the Manhattan School of Music, about five years in a row, we went to a place close to Venice, it was called Tuscafarco, and we were there for two weeks, all teaching and playing too, playing too, concerts. The faculty played at night and then we taught all day for two weeks. I did that for about five years in a row. That was nice, yeah. And then other times, just go there, in spots. I went to Spain, did a couple of clinics there on my own, and I mean with the bands too. I go with the Vanguard band, we'll do clinics individually and in sections sometimes.

MR: Do the people over there — I don't know if "respect" is the right word — do they think of jazz as more significant than here?

RL: Yeah. Because this is our gift to them. This is the only original art form that America has to offer. Original art form. I mean rock & roll is not original, it's not American. You know classical music is not original. I mean there's a lot of American composers but they're not original. I mean they might be original in their own music but I'm saying the idea of classical music is not American. The idea of jazz is American, it's an original American art form. So this is our gift to Japan, our gift to Germany. And a lot of people try to copy it. So yeah I would say they respect it. Oh yeah. Definitely. Totally.

MR: You had a statement yesterday, actually just to follow-up on rock & roll, do you have an issue with the way people behave?

RL: Oh, that's right. You know I don't know why I said that but it's true. You know it used to make me mad. You know, these little old Puerto Rican ladies who had to clean up this mess that these guys I mean they didn't have to break bottles. I mean I party too — oh it's my phone, where is my phone.

MR: That's all right, we can edit this tape.

RL: You know what, I'm not going to even answer it. I don't know who that is. I'll shut it off.

MR: I'll bet I know who it was. We were talking about rock & roll, it was probably Eric Clapton calling you "Ralph, what are you doing next week?"

RL: "I can't make it."

MR: Okay. So we were talking about rock & roll, and the behavior that sometimes is associated with that music.

RL: And I guess I just — would you appreciate it? If your mother had to clean up? I mean because I spent a lot of time in hotel rooms. And I'm not saying, I mean I party but I don't break glass and I just think these guys — it's disrespectful. And sometimes the

music sounds that way to me. Not everybody. I mean I love Jimi Hendrix, you know, I loved a lot of people when I was growing up especially, that had something to say. You know? And I'm not against that, not at all. I love James Taylor, I mean that's not rock & roll, but you know. Who was the other — Laura Nyro, Carole King, yeah, and Jimi Hendrix. I loved Jimi Hendrix. But I didn't like Cream that much. But I liked Jimi Hendrix you know what I mean?

MR: You don't have to like everybody I guess.

RL: Yeah.

MR: And speaking of learning, I have this thing that came to me yesterday when you were playing, and it has something to do with teaching I think, because I mean you can learn the *Real Book* tunes and all that, but there was stuff that you guys did yesterday that I was wondering where it came from. And one of example was you did the tune "Like Someone In Love." And near the end of it, right at the end, you played a lick, it was sort of a tag, and it sounded like: "My mama done told me."

RL: Exactly right. That's my Woody influence.

MR: So where does that come from and how do you, as a teacher, get your kids to learn all that?

RL: That's my experience. That's where that came from. I didn't think about it. We used to play it in Woody's band: "My mama done told me/to bring home the" you know whatever the words. You know, "Blues in the Night." And then when you live the stuff, see that's what I mean, when you live the stuff, see that's what I mean, when you learn it in the *Real Book* sometimes you're not living it unless you play it for a couple of years, you know, a song let's say. And that's all. And that came to my mind, because that was part of my musical growing up, you know?

MR: Okay. So that thing wasn't an outtro so to speak that I should have known about?

RL: No.

MR: Okay, you just — it sounded just like it was part of it.

RL: But it fit. I try to be melodic, musical. Yeah, that's right. Yeah, you've got to make all this fit. And that's through experience you know?

MR: Yeah, but there was a couple of other things too, like some intros and stuff that you don't see in the *Real Book*.

RL: Yeah they're not there.

MR: I guess that as a teacher you may pass those on to your students.

RL: I might show them different ways they can go with things. The reason why I would do that, not that they would copy me, they maybe copy me for a little bit but mainly so that they realize they have the freedom to do that, to use their own ingenuity, their own creativeness. You don't have to just read it like a book. You know there's a lot of people

when they learn from the Real Books and stuff, they think oh we have to do it like the book. But the book says that. No it's not. I mean that's not *The Bible*. All it is is a guide. That's the same way you play chord changes. You know because it says this doesn't mean you can't use that, you know, but it has to sound right. That's what I mean. That's where taste comes in. You know? And tension and all. Ahhh.

MR: You know what, you can use that when you go back and teach.

RL: Well I do, I think I do. But I'll even use it more because it makes more sense now.

MR: Speaking of the *Real Book* and the number of tunes in it that date back to the *Great American Songbook* —

RL: Oh sure.

MR: How come? How come those songs that were not really written as jazz tunes per se offer such a rich palette of —

RL: Well because you said it. Because the songs really, you can improvise on them. They're made perfectly to improvise. You see, I don't want to get too technical, but to me improvising is about tension to release. You have a tension and you release it, in other words you resolve it. Okay? And even when you don't resolve it, the tension is, like you said, it's up in the air, to be resolved. And that's all right too. And a lot of these American Songbooks have that. They have the tension to the release. And to put it in musical, in theoretical terms, it's the dominant to the tonic. And these tunes that we were talking about, like they might be in one key but within that form you go to about five keys. What does that mean? You have to have the tension to the release. The tension to the release. Tension to the release. So that's perfect for a jazzer, they want to deal with it, to improvise. It's like putting a carrot in front of a rabbit. You know?

MR: Well do you find it harder than, or a different kind of challenge to improvise like on a tune like "So What," where you've just got two chords and they're just —

RL: Um hum. Exactly. I understand what you mean. Well to me it's almost sometimes harder. For me. Because I mean just for the fact, well the more I study music the more I realize how many tensions are in there. See? At first I just looked at it as one thing. The Dorian mode let's say. But no, it's more than that. You start learning how you could — that's the foundation. You could learn how you start building upon it. And I'm still working on that. Thinking about that. And then you could relate that to other songs too. See that's what guys are doing today. They're taking their modal kind of things and putting it on these standards. And inside the tension to the release. You know what I'm saying? I don't want to get too technical, but that's simple I think. That's just tension to release. So you could add tension to that long 16 bars of D Dorian, and you can look at it a lot of different ways. But at first, to me, all that space made it much harder for me. For me. Not the rest of the world. That came from the Upstate, Tony Leonardi school, and Sal Nistico,

change-change-change-change-change-change. And which I loved. But I'm saying but then when I got to "So What" I said what do I do? D Dorian for eighteen thousand years. And then it goes up a half step. But you know, but I mean, but to me they're both great. But yeah, it does present a challenge, because that's hard to resolve with all that movement with keys in the Songbook, that's hard too. Because you've got to know your keys. But you've got to know your keys when you're talking about superimposition on the Dorian mode. See? So it's all the same.

MR: Is there a short list of things that you really want your students to be able to do by the time they move on?

RL: Oh sure.

MR: And what might be a couple of them?

RL: Well play in time. Have a good tone. Play in time with the rhythm, not just rhythmically correct but the harmonic rhythm, the harmonic rhythm. That means like when you're playing these standards or playing the modal stuff, you're playing the harmony it has to have, the rhythm of the harmony has to resolve in the right places. Because there's corny places to resolve, and there's hip places to resolve. You know what I'm saying? So and not to get too into it, but that's my criteria. You've got to learn how to do that, if you want to be my student. You know, and that's great, they love it because now it starts to make sense what they're playing.

MR: What method do you use in a lesson? Do you play chords with them?

RL: Sometimes. Sometimes I play on saxophone. If they don't hear it I go to the piano and say you're playing this note. I'll play the chord and say, "Here's the note you landed on." And they say, "Oh yeah. Now I know what you mean by wrong and tension." There it goes again.

MR: Well along the similar lines, what makes things individually or as a rhythm section, what makes things swing?

RL: Ooh. What makes things swing. Well it's feeling. Hmm how could I say it. You mean technically what makes things swing?

MR: If you were listening to a rhythm section or you were on one of those gigs just like this weekend where you get with a group and you can tell right after the first couple of times, well this band really swings, or this thing does not really swing. Is it possible to put that into words.

RL: Yeah okay well I'll try, now I'm understanding you better. To me, when people play together more, they're in the same thought zone, that usually swings. And not that all swinging is the same, but it usually gets off the ground, I like to put it. You know what I mean? And it's magic that happens. And that's usually swinging. You know what I mean? Now the technical thing is the way they play the eighth notes. In other words,

some guys, I know I have a lot of students that come in out of high school and they think swinging is [scats]. To me you're putting two eighth notes like more like a dotted eighth and a sixteenth. And that's not it. It's more of a triplet. [scats]. So that's the technical thing. And it's not just the drummer and the bass player, it's also the horn players too. [scats]. That's not it. So that adds to the not-swing. And why it's not swing is because one guy is maybe swinging and the other guy's going [scats] so that's not together. So as a band that's not happening. It's not gelling. It's not magic. You know what I mean? It's not getting off the ground. It's not leaving the earth. Okay? But when it is leaving the earth — the same with a funk band, if you're a great funk band it's the same thing. Boy they're so together. You know? It lifts you right off the ground, you know what I mean? And a symphony orchestra. When it's totally together, it's swinging man. You know what I'm saying? It's not swinging — that's not what I'm talking about. I'm talking about togetherness. You know? And the world can learn a lot from that too. And politicians can learn a lot from that. The democrats and the republicans can learn a lot about that, doing it together. You know what I mean? Not I say black you say orange. I say furnace you say snowflake.

MR: I thought of this question when you said your wife was a singer. Do you play a melody of a tune differently if it has a well-known lyric?

RL: You know ever since I've been married, yes. I mean now I know a lot of the words, I'm not going to lie to you and say I studied the words, even though Lester Young did and a lot of people do. But I'm playing with my wife a lot more, you know, and I hear the lyrics. You know I'm on the bandstand and I listen to her sing, and I say wow that's a great lyric. And she's great, and she writes lyrics. And we just did a gig at Cornelia Street in the Village, it was totally jammed. And the reason why they hired her, and they had me too, but they hired her was because she wrote a lot of lyrics on — not the American Songbook — but the jazz. Like "Nica's Dream," "Dolphin Dance," "Sugar" by Stanley Turrentine, and so they wanted her to do it, to hear her lyrics on these songs. And they hired me too because I play. But you know that's how good she is. So, and then when she sings the song I really hear the lyrics. So it made me appreciate the lyrics more and the song more, definitely. And now hopefully I do, I play differently now that I'm — I can't recite every lyric but you know I remember the bridge, I remember what it's trying to say, you know what I mean? You know maybe not specifically all the time like to quote it, like she could, but I'd know what it's trying to say. You know, it helps. Yeah. Soulful.

MR: What's it like to, is your wife professional? I mean does she make her living singing?

RL: Oh yeah. Well she's got a day job too, because no, she's been a professional for a long time. And we have a couple of records. And we have a record out together, "In a Word," Don Friedman, Dennis Irwin, Ralph LaLama and Nicole Pasternak, with no drums. And

it was totally in a word, now check this out, it's called "In a Word" and all the titles of the songs are one word: "Smile," you know, "Four," "You," you know I can't remember everything. But you know it's like twelve tunes or something, and they're all one word. So the name of the CD is called "In a Word."

MR: What's it like to make a living as musicians?

RL: Well it's challenging but it's fun and it's, I mean I'm so into it now, I could probably answer that question better twenty years ago. You know what I mean? But now I mean it's just a way of life. It's just the way it is and it's a lot of fun and it's a challenge business-wise, it's a challenge financially, and it's a challenge to better yourself in the midst of all that. You know what I mean? And to make a living. But I'm lucky I have people, like I say I have pretty good gigs and I teach too, which I like, I'm not a guy that doesn't like it. Two schools, NYU for twenty-three years and SUNY Purchase for about ten or eleven. And I teach privately too. And I do clinics and concerts, and I still play. You know I have a full schedule. So that's why I make a living.

MR: Again I'm not sure how to ask this question but I'll try.

RL: Monk, you're doing a great job.

MR: Pardon?

RL: You're doing a great job.

MR: Well thank you.

RL: No they're good questions.

MR: You are a middle-aged white guy. That's my astute observation. Does that affect getting gigs?

RL: You know, okay, that's a great question. I'll go back to when I grew up. I grew up near Pittsburgh in a place called Aliquippa, West Aliquippa, Pennsylvania. And my grandmother, my mother's mother, lived in a part of Aliquippa which was called Plan Eleven. Now Plan Eleven was all black except one white family, hers. Okay? And when I was a kid we would go there on Sunday to see my grandparents and hang out in the yard and next to the yard was another ball field, where the cats would play, the neighborhood would play. And eventually I would go start playing with them. So I learned how to play sports, you know, with pretty good players. And then I went to high school and I ended up knowing these guys in high school, so I kind of knew them before I got to high school. I went to a Catholic high school in West Aliquippa, which, there was no black people in West Aliquippa. So I never even thought about it, because these guys were my friends, and we used to use racial slurs all the time and it was not, it was nothing, it was like, "Hey man," "hi dude," "how you doin'," and that's not the words we'd use but that's the way we talked and it had no problem until I got to New York and I heard I wasn't supposed to be talking like that. And I said you've got to be kidding me. Okay. Now I'm

on the jazz scene where there's supposed to be racial stuff. And I'll tell you another story. You ever heard of Stanley Crouch?

MR: Yes.

RL: Okay. I used to play with this guy named Sadik Hakim, which his real name was Argonne Thornton, he used to play with Bird. He was a kid when he played with Bird. He lived with Bird, he wasn't that good, he was learning how to play. He wasn't Bud Powell, but Bird let him play when Hakim did a record with Bird and Argonne now is grown up and I moved to New York and he befriended me. Okay? He was an older black guy, a great piano player at that time.

MR: Sorry, his name now?

RL: Sadik Hakim. Yeah. He's dead. But he lived in the lower East side and, but he was a real jazzer man. He kind of played between, he had originals, he wrote thousands of tunes and he had a lot of originals that sounded like between Monk and Duke and Horace, you know those kinds of tunes. He wrote great tunes. And every time — he was pretty famous so he would do a lot of trio gigs. And he would have quartet gigs and he would use me, because I would go play with him a lot and I liked his tunes, so we got along, I guess he liked me. So one time there was a place called the Tin Palace. And Sadik got a gig there and then he was going to use me, and Stanley Crouch used to book him. And then he goes, Stanley said, "Who do you have in the group?" Uh bu-bu-bu "I have this tenor player you probably never heard of named Ralph LaLama." "No I never heard of him. Is he white?" "Yeah." Na, na, na, na, don't get — get Junior Cook. Okay. So Sadik told me this. Okay? So I go to the Tin Palace and they were playing, and I brought my horn to sit in. See? And I love Junior Cook. I wasn't trying to blow any — I couldn't, because I was a kid. But anyway, to make a long story short, so I went there to play, and then Stan, and he said "this is Ralph LaLama." Okay. And I could have got out on Stanley and I didn't. Something told me no. Because Stanley I knew, he's a writer, I like Stanley actually, but at that time I didn't really like him too much. Okay. Now, now, now he wrote, I'll forward to about ten years later, and now I'm on the scene more you know. And Stanley comes down to the Vanguard, he knows who I am, so he wrote an article in the *Village Voice* called "The Tell of the Tenor," you know in other words talking about the backstory, from Chu Berry until now, at that time, probably about twelve or fifteen years ago. But it was ten years later after the scene at the Tin Palace. And to make a long story short, he was talking about Lester Young, Coltrane, Sonny Rollins, all the great tenor players, and then at the end he started talking about now we've got guys like ba-ba-ba we've got this guy, we've got this guy, and Joshua Redman, and then the three Caucasian tenor players that I like who are on the New York scene is Ralph LaLama, Joe Lovano and Mike Brecker. I said yes. So I mean because I had a little restraint. Because see it

didn't bother me because of the way I grew up. That's why I didn't mean to tell you this long story but you asked the question and I had a history with it. I never thought that way because I know it's black music, that's why I like it. You know, because to me this music is killing. I really don't like white music, to tell you the truth. I'm serious. That's what bothers me sometimes about rock & roll too, it's just a little too Caucasian for me, and I'm just telling you the truth okay. That's the way I grew up, what am I going to do? So anyway, so the point of it is that he wrote that so it all worked out you know what I mean? He wrote that thing about putting my name in the paper and put those guys, Lovano and Michael. That was great. So it worked out. But I guess in some people's mind it does hinder you and in some people's mind it helps you too, you know, I guess. Some people won't hire you because you're white I guess and some people will hire you because you're white. But I have a lot of friends, I don't really think of it that way. I know people do. But I don't care. You know these guys are friends of mine. I don't think about black or white. They're friends. They've always been friends. And pre-grade school. I learned how to play sports, you know I could play sports too because of these guys, but I could play with the old guys. These guys would kick my butt you know. Does that answer your question?

MR: Yeah that's a good answer. That's a good story.

RL: Okay.

MR: If you had the circumstances to teach a jazz class, let's say a non-musician jazz class, let's suppose they were like almost senior citizens, and some of the people said "I just don't get it, when the musicians just start going off, I don't understand what they're doing." Is there a way to explain jazz improvisation to that kind of person.

RL: Yes. I would tell them they would have to listen more. You know they would have to listen more, and maybe start off not listening to Coltrane. Start off listening to Lester Young. It's just like learning a language. If you had a little kid crawling here he'd be going ma-maw-mama — you know he couldn't speak it, even though we are speaking. He would catch it and catch it and catch it and then by the time he is sixteen he would say "hey Monk, buy me a car." He knows how to speak that. Or she knows. Right? So it's learning the language. You've have to get acclimated to it. And as far as liking it, you know I didn't like broccoli when I was five years old or ten years old or fifteen years old. Now I eat broccoli every day. It grows on you, you know what I mean? And I know, that's a good question, because I know just anybody, when I play I have a thousand people walk up to me and say, you know I never heard jazz before but I like this. You know what I mean? And I see it on people's faces if they've never been to a place before or a concert, they look at you like you're nuts, you know? Because maybe we were a little too strong for that moment for them. They should go back and listen and you know

listen to bla-bla-bla, you know? Sometimes you've got to acquire a taste or sometimes you don't have time to acquire it, sometimes it hits you right away you just never knew it.

MR: Do you think you change your playing to fit certain different circumstances?

RL: Oh yeah. I do. Oh I'm definitely influenced by the moment and by the place and by the environment. Oh sure. Definitely. Like if I was to play a concert for a bunch of old people let's say, tunes I would pick I would play differently than I would play for, like I say a college crowd. Definitely. And even the club. Like I play Small's a lot, Small's.

MR: It's on, you can get that on video live, right?

RL: Oh yes, that's right. I'm usually there, one Saturday every month, at 7:30, yeah. And I play a trio, Bop Juice, it's a trio, with Clifford Barbaro, and the bass player du jour and me. So it's Bop Juice.

MR: Bass player du jour.

RL: Yeah. Because you know bass players get too many gigs, so you know I have a bunch of guys I use.

MR: Interesting, yeah.

RL: Yeah, yeah, yeah. They work all the time so sometimes they can't make 7:30 on a Saturday night.

MR: Right. You start going down your list.

RL: Yeah, yeah yeah.

MR: You know, some things are the same on any level.

RL: That's right. That's right, sure, oh definitely. Well what was the question?

MR: The question was altering your playing somewhat for different circumstances.

RL: Yeah. I definitely do that. Yes. The crowd, yes. I mean that's just the way I am. That's just the way I see things. It's like if you walked in a room and the President of the United States was here you would talk to him differently than if the janitor was here. Not that — I wouldn't have any less respect for the janitor, but that's the way I grew up, that's the way my father was and is. He can talk to anybody about anything. So that's my influence. But I would talk to him differently though.

MR: Has the explosion in technology in the last ten years had an effect on what you do?

RL: Not what I do but I think it has an effect on the scene. Yeah. Because that's the way people are living and people, especially with the computers, I don't feel, even the cell phones, I don't feel that there's so much personal contact. I remember when I walked down the street, "Hey man how you doin'?" Now it's like you can't even get their attention {mumbles}. And they're driving, and stay in your lane, and when are you going to pick out the furniture? You know they're hugging you. What do you want to propose? I mean I don't know I just think that, I don't know if that's the technology you're talking about but I think it's the way of the world. But what I like about the technology is the

way you can communicate. Email, I could call Europe for free. Or I could email a thousand things at one time. And it's be great. That's great business. I love it. I really do, I love it. I think that's the greatest thing. But like I have a lot of students, and their whole life is just doing this. And that really is absorbed. Because there's so many things to absorb that you don't absorb anything. And then the communication skills are — actually could you talk? What's your name? Duh? What are you trying to tell me? Because their communication skills are down. They don't interact. And I don't think that's good, we're human beings, we've got to interact, we've got to have relationships, you know what I mean? Even in business. We've got to have relationships with people. Jazz business, lawyer business, doctor business, garbage can business, paint business, you know? It's called relationships.

MR: Is there less of an initiative these days to make recordings because of the way they get sent out and often times lifted for free.

RL: Oh yeah. I don't know if there's less. I mean maybe you would think that way in philosophy but in reality I don't think it's less at all, I think it's more, because everybody can do it. You know what I mean? But I don't think it's that — I don't know what the word is — I don't think it works out that well because of that, the download for free, you know you don't make any money you know what I mean? And so I'm saying the reality doesn't seem like it really has a deterrent on it. It seems like it's more, because it's easier to do.

MR: Yes. It's easier to do.

RL: Yeah, yeah. So like anybody can make a record, a CD, anybody. So to me and that brings down the quality too. You know what I mean? I have a CD out, I shouldn't — I'm not saying you couldn't for ten years, but right now you shouldn't be worrying about that, you should be trying to make relationships. You know what I mean?

MR: Good point. Do you have any short or long term goals?

RL: Oh I'm never good at that, I'm serious. My wife always asks me, I say no. I just, I'm always thinking ahead. That's my short term and my long term. As I grow I say what's the next step? One thing I have to say about myself, I've been living in New York for thirty-five years and I never went backwards. You know what I mean? I mean either financially or career-wise, I mean God, I never really got sick or something, then you'd go backwards. But it's always, everything got better. Yeah. I'd have to say that.

MR: Did you ever have to work day gigs?

RL: Well I do, teaching.

MR: The teaching.

RL: Yeah. And I used to have, the day gig for me back in the beginning was playing weddings and bar mitzvahs, which I didn't mind that much, because I just don't care.

MR: You said that yesterday that it was better to do that —

RL: Yeah than go work out —

MR: Than to do data entry or something.

RL: Yeah, what is that called, when you're — there was a word for that — word processing, but you were a something, when you were — a word processor, does that make sense? And there's nothing wrong with that, believe me. It's like being a secretary for a corporation. But if you're a musician and you move to New York, you understand, you leave your family and you move to New York to make it — I don't know what that means — but make a living at playing your instrument or writing or composing or whatever, dancing. Why the hell would you leave that and go be a word processor? It has nothing to do with people who do it or secretaries, that's great, I mean they can learn the computer more. I wish I knew more about the computer. That's not what I'm talking about. I'm just talking about why do you spend forty hours a week and make three hundred dollars at that time, not now, and I can make two-hundred fifty dollars in one wedding and still have a horn in my mouth, and try to pick up the bridesmaid. Sorry baby, that was a long time ago, before I met you.

MR: Have you ever had a circumstance with a student who had the desire but really not the inherent talent?

RL: Yes. Many times. Okay? And I teach him how to teach. I teach him how to listen. I teach him how to communicate with what they know, and they usually have the talent to absorb knowledge. And some of them have a talent to communicate. And as far as playing, yeah, but I still encourage them to play because it's good therapy. You see if you're a teacher you need therapy. But I can tell they're never going to really get off the ground with it on a really high professional level, because they just don't have the talent, but they really have the desire and they want to be involved. And you can be involved, as a teacher and even maybe a speaker, maybe a clinician. You don't have to be a great player to be a clinician, you've just got to give out the right information.

MR: That's interesting.

RL: And also a listener, a fan, teach them how to be a fan. I mean I know that sounds selfish but it's not. You know this jazz world needs fans that are into it, that have a passion for it. The best fan is the guy that has a passion for it, not just somebody because they think it's hip, you know, the flavor of the month. You know what I mean?

MR: That's an excellent answer to that question.

RL: But it's true.

MR: That's the best answer I've got is to teach them to be a teacher or a jazz fan.

RL: Or a fan, yeah. And they won't have any problem with that because you know they can still get off. It's a lot of satisfaction.

MR: Well on that note, we're going to get you to your train.

RL: Oh yeah.

MR: We're in good shape here, so it's been a real pleasure.

RL: But wait, they're supposed to be here. They have my horn and my stuff.

MR: They're here.

RL: But they're taking me, right?

MR: We're in good shape.

RL: Okay.

MR: Thanks for your time.

RL: Monk, thank you man, it was fun, really.